industries and Common Effluent Treatment Plants. These systems will detect anomalies and help shift from reactive enforcement to predictive governance.

We've expanded real-time monitoring systems and hired additional technical staff. Through YASHADA, we trained 450 staff members in 2024, focusing on technical updates, managerial skills, and legal knowledge.

Our strategic tie-up with colleges fosters environmental innovation among students. We've modernised regulations with a new Ready-Mix Concrete Policy for MMR and improved Ease of Doing Business through streamlined application processing.

This is "practical idealism" using technology to solve real problems, with young people contributing fresh perspectives to governance challenges.

## The Political Imperative

Environmental action is often seen as separate from political leadership. That's a mistake. Climate change doesn't respect party lines, and neither should environmental solutions.

As a Shiv Sena member, I believe our responsibility to Maharashtra extends beyond electoral cycles. We're custodians of a state that has given India its commercial capital and entrepreneurial spirit. We cannot be the generation that hands over polluted rivers and toxic air to our children.

This isn't about being pro-business or pro-environment. It's about being pro-Maharashtra. It's about ensuring our industries thrive without compromising people's health, and that Mumbai remains a city where young professionals want to build careers.

But political commitment means more than policy statements. It means changing how we do politics. For too long, environmental issues have been treated as technical problems to be solved by experts behind closed doors. The reality is that environmental challenges are fundamentally about choices—choices about what kind of future we want, what trade-offs we're willing to make, and whose voices get heard in decision-making processes.

That's why I've made youth engagement a non-negotiable part of MPCB's governance approach. When young people bring environmental concerns to political leaders, they're not asking for charity—they're demanding accountability. They're asking us to govern with their future in mind, not just the next election cycle. This is where political leadership and environmental stewardship must converge. True political success in the 21st century will be measured not just by economic growth or electoral victories, but by whether we've created sustainable systems that serve future generations.

## The Road Ahead

Our priorities are clear: launching the Mahaparyavaran app statewide, establishing Environmental Resource Cells at divisional levels, scaling real-time monitoring systems, and developing our Real-Time Water Quality Monitoring network.

We're expanding capacity-building programs through YASHADA and rolling out formal partnerships with academic institutions. But more than programs and policies, we need a mindset shift. Young Maharashtrians must see environmental action not as an obligation, but as an opportunity to innovate, lead, build businesses, and create the Maharashtra they want to live in.

## A Personal Commitment

As someone who believes actions speak louder than words, let me end with specific commitments: every major environmental decision at MPCB will include youth perspectives. Every policy will incorporate student feedback. Every program will create opportunities for young environmental leaders.

But I'm going further than consultation. Starting this year, MPCB will reserve seats for youth representatives on our technical advisory committees. Young professionals and students will have voting rights, not just speaking opportunities. We're establishing mentorship programs where experienced environmentalists work alongside young innovators, creating knowledge exchange that flows both ways.

Our college partnerships won't be limited to seminars and workshops. Student teams will be embedded in our field operations, our policy development processes, and our technology implementations. When we design air quality monitoring systems, computer science students will be part of the development team. When we plan river rejuvenation projects, environmental science students will help shape the implementation strategy.

This isn't political posturing. This is practical governance that recognises a simple truth: the people who will live longest with our environmental decisions should have the strongest voice in making them.

Young Maharashtrians have been talking about environmental solutions for years. Now it's time for them to implement those solutions with the full backing of government infrastructure and political support.

The student in Pune who questioned me about climate action represents the kind of youth leadership we need—young people who aren't waiting for permission but taking charge of their environmental future.

**That's the Maharashtra I believe in. That's the future we're building together.**

- **For a cleaner Maharashtra.**
- **For a greener Maharashtra**.
- **For a youth-powered Maharashtra.**

Siddhesh Kadam is Chairman of the Maharashtra Pollution Control Board and Mumbai Chapter In-charge of Shiv Sena. He can be reached at connect@siddheshkadam.in

